sess their well-being strategies to make sure they are holistic and encompass health benefits, fair compensation and work-life balance. They also need to be vigilant about signs of stress among employees. Any prolonged mental health issue, such as persistent anxiety, stress or sadness lasting more than two weeks, should be evaluated by a mental health professional.

Employee wellness programmes were a crucial consideration for 72 per cent of job-seekers in their decision-making process, as the CII-MediBuddy report found, reflecting the growing demand for personalised wellness solutions and easy healthcare access at office. Most big companies have started offering mental health benefits, including counselling services, anonymous helplines and wellness leave policies. Global home furnishing brand IKEA, for instance, employs a full-time health and well-being officer to create a caring, healthy and safe work environment for its 3,500 employees. Battery-makers Amara Raja have a team of eight members responsible for the well-being of their 17,000-plus employees, in addition to a peer support network of 29 senior managers and 294 supervisors, all trained in counselling, conflict management and coping mechanisms to promote emotional wellness.

Counselling support is also becoming an integral part of mental health benefits. Companies like Amara Raja, IKEA and RPG provide on-site counsellors 2-3 times a week, with online services available for family members as well. People are also beginning to avail the services. "Four or five years ago, when we introduced counsellors in the office, hardly anyone used the service," says Jaikrishna B., president, Group HR, at the Amara Raja Group. "But now, the number of people seeking counselling is growing by 15-20 per cent year-on-year, which shows that employees view the company as a safe space to share their concerns." To date, employees at Amara Raja have utilised 4,500 counselling sessions, of which 1,800 were in-person and the rest online.

To keep the momentum around mental health going, diversified conglomerate ITC conducts monthly webinars on various health topics such as obesity, workplace ergonomics, depression and managing workload. These have been attended by over 1,200 people, says Amitav Mukherji, head of corporate human resources, ITC. Other companies have devised their own solutions. Consumer products company Marico has multiple formal and informal listening forums, quarterly engagement surveys and regular check-ins with supervisors to enable employees to voice their concerns openly, says their CHRO Amit Prakash.

IKEA even has a 'Quiet Room' with a comfortable bed where employees can take a break and recharge. "We also provide flexibility, allowing employees to switch from a 40-hour to a 32-hour contract, or to part-time roles if needed, and revert when their situation changes," says Parineeta Cecil Lakra, country people and culture manager at IKEA India. Similarly, the RPG Group allows its employees, irrespective of their designation, to work remotely for 50 per cent of their working hours.



"More companies today are aware about the importance of mental health, but it is not enough. This trend has to grow"



- NEERJA BIRLA
Founder-chairperson, Mpower

LEADING BY EXAMPLE

Companies are also realising that their initiatives amount to nothing if there is no leadership buy-in. Leaders at IKEA, therefore, set an example by openly discussing their own time off, encouraging others to use their earned leave, says Lakra. "We have an 85 per cent leave utilisation rate across all levels," she says. Capillary Technologies founder and CEO Aneesh Reddy personally leads the initiative to organise mindfulness and yoga retreats, sending a clear message that the company genuinely cares about its employees' well-being. "We conduct two such retreats on the outskirts of Bengaluru each year. They have seen participation from over 100 employees," says Reddy. The company also offers an 11-day Vipassana leave for employees apart from their annual leave. Reddy himself takes this leave every year.

But even as they make these efforts, companies must also examine their very organisational structure. They cannot overwhelm employees with unrealistic targets and then of-